

The Last Leaf

At the top of a three-story brick building, Sue and Johnsy had their studio. “Johnsy” was familiar¹ for Joanna. One was from Maine; the other from California. They had met at a café on Eighth Street and found their tastes in art, chicory salad and bishop sleeves so much in tune² that the joint studio resulted.

1. Here, familiar means intimate. “Johnsy” is a very intimate name for Joanna.
2. In tune is an idiom(惯用语), which means in harmony.

That was in May. In November a cold, unseen stranger, whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the district, touching one here and there with his icy fingers. Johnsy was among his victims. She lay, scarcely(=rarely, hardly) moving on her bed(躺着一动不动), looking through the small window at the blank side of the next brick house.

One morning the busy doctor invited Sue into the hallway with a bushy, gray eyebrow.

“She has one chance in ten,” he said. “And that chance is for her to want to live. Your little lady has made up her mind that she’s not going to get well. Has she anything on her mind?”

“She - she wanted to paint the Bay of Naples some day,” said Sue.

“Paint? - bosh! Has she anything on her mind worth³ thinking about twice - a man, for instance?”

3. Worth is a preposition. Worth 最常用的词性是介词，介词后面的动词要加-ing。E.g. Johnsy has nothing worth thinking seriously. / It is worth checking the details before you sign this contract. Worth 也可以表示名词，价值，value。但不用作动词。

“A man?” said Sue. “Is a man worth - but, no, doctor; there is nothing of the kind.”

“Well,” said the doctor. “I will do all that science can accomplish. But whenever my patient begins to count the carriages in her funeral procession⁴ I subtract(=reduce) 50% from the curative power of medicines.” After the doctor had gone Sue went into the workroom and cried. Then she marched(=walk) into Johnsy’s room with her drawing board, whistling a merry⁵ tune⁶.

4. Procession means parade; it is a line of people moving slowly as part of a ceremony 它表示游行队伍；
5. Don’t confound “merry” with “marry”. Merry means cheerful, pleasant, happy;
6. Don’t confound “tune” with “tone”. Tune means melody, musical notes 调子，曲调，while tone means the way your voice sounds, which often reveals how you feel. 它表示说话的语调、语气。

Johnsy lay, scarcely making a movement under the bedclothes, with her face toward the window. She was looking out and counting - counting backward(倒着数).

“Twelve,” she said, and a little later “eleven”; and then “ten,” and “nine”; and then “eight” and “seven,” almost together.

Sue looked out of the window. What was there to count? There was only a bare, dreary yard to be seen, and the blank side of the brick house twenty feet away. An old, old ivy vine climbed half way up the brick wall. The cold breath of autumn had blown away its leaves,

leaving it almost **bare**⁷.

7. Bare means without any covering, exposed, 裸露在外的, e.g. A bare bone, 一根光秃秃的骨头;

"Six," said Johnsy, in almost a **whisper**⁸. "They're falling faster now. Three days ago there were almost a hundred. It made my head ache to count them. But now it's easy. There goes another one. There are only five left now."

8. Whisper is whisper, whistle is whistle; don't confound them. Whisper means to speak softly with little sound, while whistle means to blow a sound. 前者为低声说, 小声低语, 后者是吹口哨。

"Five what, dear?"

"Leaves. On the ivy vine. When the last one falls I must go, too. I've known that for three days. Didn't the doctor tell you?"

"Oh, I never heard of such nonsense. What have old ivy leaves to do with your getting well? Don't be so **silly**. Why, the doctor told me this morning that your chances for getting well real soon were to to one! Try to take some soup now, and let Sudie go and buy port wine for sick child."

"You needn't get any more wine," said Johnsy, **keeping her eyes fixed**⁹ out the window. "There goes another. No. I don't want any soup. That leaves four. I want to see the last one fall before it gets dark. Then I'll go, too. I'm tired of waiting. I'm tired of thinking. I want to **turn loose my hold on**¹⁰ everything, and go sailing down, down, just like one of those poor, tired leaves."

9. Keep the eyes fixed, 紧盯着某物, e.g. She keeps her eyes fixed on the fire in the distance.

10. Turn loose one's hold on everything means that someone voluntarily give up control of everything, 撒开一切, 撒手不管;

"Try to sleep," said Sue. "I must call Behrman up to be my model for the old miner. I'll not be gone a minute."

Old Behrman was a painter who lived on the ground floor beneath them. He was past sixty and had a long white beard **curling** down over his **chest**. Despite looking the part, Behrman was a failure in art. For forty years he had been always about to paint a masterpiece, but had never yet begun it. He earned a little by serving as a model to those young artists who could not pay the price of a professional. He drank gin to excess, and still talked of his coming masterpiece. For the rest he was a **fierce** little old man, who **mocked** terribly **at**¹¹ softness in any one, and who regarded himself as guard dog to the two young artists in the studio above.

11. Mock at has many synonyms, for example, to ridicule, to make fun of, to tease, to ironise, 嘲讽, 讥笑;

Sue found Behrman smelling strongly of gin in his **dimly**¹² lighted studio below. In one corner was a blank **canvas** on an easel that had been waiting there for twenty-five years to receive the first line of the masterpiece. She told him of Johnsy's **fancy**, and how she feared she would, indeed, light and fragile as a leaf herself, float away, when her slight hold upon the world grew weaker. Old Behrman, with his red eyes **plainly streaming**¹³, shouted his **contempt** for such foolish imaginings(=imagination).

12. Dim means lacking lightness, 昏暗的; it also means unfavorable, negative, disapproving 表示不看好的. E.g. a dim future, takes a dim(negative) point of view.
13. Stream means emit or discharge 流出(液体), plainly means obviously. 原文的意思是 他发红的眼眶里噙满泪水。

“What!” he cried. “Are there people in the world foolish enough to die because leaves drop off from a vine? I have never heard of such a thing. Why do you allow such silly ideas to come into that head of hers? God! This is not a place in which one so good as Miss Johnsy should lie sick. Some day I will paint a masterpiece, and we shall all go away. Yes.”

Johnsy was sleeping when they went upstairs. Sue pulled the shade down, and motioned(=gesture 打手势, 招呼) Behrman into the other room. In there they peered out the window fearfully at the ivy vine. Then they looked at each other for a moment without speaking. A persistent, cold rain was falling, mingled with snow. Behrman, in his old blue shirt, took his seat as the miner on an upturned kettle for a rock¹⁴.

14. 最后这句话可能理解起来比较困难。Behrman was wearing his old blue shirt, why? Because he was acting the model of a mine worker for Sue. 他穿着蓝色工装, 扮演着矿工。Where did he sit? He was sitting on a rock. Sue used “an upturned kettle” as the rock. 苏 Sue 用一个底朝天的水壶当成岩矿, 让 Behrman 身着矿工服饰坐上去。

When Sue awoke from an hour's sleep the next morning she found Johnsy with dull¹⁵, wide-open eyes staring at the drawn¹⁶ green shade.

15. Johnsy with dull, wide-open eyes...Dull here means lacking colour, brilliance, 失去光泽, 无神的;
16. Please draw the curtain. 请拉上窗帘。所以, the drawn green shade means the shade which is drawn, 关闭着的帘子;

“Pull it up; I want to see,” she ordered, in a whisper.

Wearily¹⁷ Sue obeyed.

17. Weary means tired, exhausted, lacking vigour or freshness.

But, Lo! After the beating rain and fierce wind that had endured¹¹ through the night, there yet stood out against the brick wall one ivy leaf. It was the last on the vine. Still dark green near its stem, but with its edges colored yellow, it hung(挂 hang, hung, hung) bravely from a branch some twenty feet above the ground.

18. endure 是一个高级词汇, 我们常说的“要有耐力”, “坚韧不拔”, “不畏艰难”都可用该词。Endure means to carry on or keep on despite hardships, difficulties. E.g. Should hard times be endured or escaped? 人应承受艰难还是避开艰难?

“It is the last one,” said Johnsy. “I thought it would surely fall during the night. I heard the wind. It will fall today, and I shall die at the same time.”

The day wore away, and even through the twilight they could see the lone¹⁹ ivy leaf clinging to its stem against the wall. And then, with the coming of the night the north wind was again loosed.

19. Attention! Here, lone does not mean lonely, solitary; instead, it means only, sole(唯一的)...they could see the lone ivy leaf clinging to its stem means that they could see the only or the last ivy leaf attached to the stem. 唯一一片或最后一片叶子依附在藤上。

When it was light enough Johnsy, the merciless, commanded that the shade be raised.

They ivy leaf was still there.

Johnsy lay for a long time looking at it. And then she called to Sue, who was stirring(拿着勺子搅拌) her chicken soup over the gas stove.

"I've been a bad girl, Sudie," said Johnsy. "Something has made that last leaf stay there to show me how wicked I was. It is a sin to want to die. You may bring me a little soup now, and some milk with a little port in it and - no; bring me a hand-mirror first, and then pack(=stack 垫一些枕头)_some pillows about(=around) me, and I will sit up(坐起来) and watch you cook."

An hour later she said:

"Sudie, some day I hope to paint the Bay of Naples."

The doctor came in the afternoon, and Sue had an excuse to go into the hallway as he left.

"Even chances," said the doctor, taking Sue's thin, shaking hand in his.

"With good nursing²⁰ you'll win. And now I must see another case I have downstairs. Behrman, his name is - some kind of an artist, I believe. Pneumonia, too. He is an old, weak man, and the attack is acute. There is no hope for him; but he goes to the hospital today to be made more comfortable."

20. 同学们还记得老师讲解的-ing 的功能吗? 这里的-ing 后缀的功能是将具象名词抽象化。所以 nursing 表示护理, 也就等于 care。

The next day the doctor said to Sue: "She's out of danger. You've won. The right food and care now - that's all."

And that afternoon Sue came to the bed where Johnsy lay and put one arm around her.

"I have something to tell you, white mouse," she said. "Mr. Behrman died of pneumonia today in the hospital. He was ill only two days. He was found on the morning of the first day in his room downstairs helpless with pain. His shoes and clothing were wet through the icy cold. They couldn't imagine where he had been on such a terrible night. And then they found a lantern, still lighted, and a ladder that had been dragged from its place, and some scattered¹² brushes, and a palette with green and yellow colors mixed on it, and - look out the window, dear, at the last ivy leaf on the wall, didn't you wonder why it never fluttered or moved when the wind blew? An, darling, it's Behrman's masterpiece - he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell."

21. Scatter 是一个国内外考试出镜率非常高的词汇。Scatter means to cause to separate and go in different directions 表示四处散落的。我们即可以说: Brushes were scattered everywhere, 也可以说 Brushes scattered everywhere. 都表示画笔刷被撒落/散落一地。